

CITIZENS Can

Citizen organisations reject venal politicians and the corrupt constabulary, building an engaged society for 2010



CITIZENS SEEKING JUSTICE FOR JESSICA LALL

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- From Resident Welfare Groups that can roll back high electricity bills to the RTI Act, the *aam aadmi* today is a powerful crusader.
- TV-channelised emotions and candlelight vigils have now become an effective tool to mobilise public opinion, from expressing outrage at the inept handling of the 26/11 attacks to the conviction of the guilty in Priyadarshini Mattoo and Jessica Lal cases.
- Technology helps, as in the Pink Chaddi campaign on Facebook against Sri Ram Sene chief Pramod Muthalik.

By Abha Dawesar |

Lathi-wielding, light-eyed Sampat Pal Devi is emblematic of where 21st century India and democracies all over the world are headed. We the people are fed up with venal politicians and the corrupt constabulary, of accepting the choices made in our interest by those higher up in the hierarchy. From Bundelkhand to the indigenous people of Ecuador, the trend is the same. We are fed up of the promises made before elections and the same old story after. We can change this. We will. We already are.

There have been people's movements before. There have been many great leaders who have mobilised the masses. But now the masses are mobilising themselves. Sampat Pal Devi is an ordinary woman though not without charisma. Married before the age of 10, a mother at 13, she now leads an army of women dressed in pink saris. In their bright uniform, the members of the Gulabi Gang sing as they walk with lathis to their next destination. Some of them are barefoot, others in chappals.

Alone they are mothers, daughters-in-laws and workers, often oppressed. Sampat Pal's vision was to realise that together they can be an unstoppable force. They have confronted officials, who have created roadblocks in the way of sanctioned development projects, waved their lathis in front of men who abuse their wives, and turned the well-worn soles of their chappals into weapons for social justice. In one symbolic moment, they broke the *kursi* of an official to make the point that without his position he was just like them, the ordinary and equal citizen of a democracy. They want to teach themselves to read, write; they are doing all of it. Their organisation has a website set up by well-wishers and a Facebook page.

While the Gulabi Gang might seem like a singular story of fierce women in yet another dacoit-prone area that takes on the might of the masculine empire, let us not forget it is only one of over a million citizen organisations in India. Each of these organisations is like a brain with individual neurons firing furiously and connecting up with one other, signalling their way up-